Greece and North Africa

Italy was Germany's ally in the war and launched invasions into North Africa and Greece. However, Italy failed to take Greece and was forced to ask Germany for aid in 1941.

Benito Mussolini came to power in 1922 and very much supported a dictatorship. He thought of himself as the new Caesar and of Italy as the Roman Empire. In his attempt to begin building a kingdom deserving of his old antecedents, Italy took for itself Ethiopia (known as Abyssinia at the time) in 1936 and Albania in 1939. On May 16th, 1940, Churchill had pleaded with Mussolini not to declare war: 'Is it too late to stop a river of blood from flowing between the British and Italian peoples?' The plea went ignored by Mussolini who said 'One moment on a battlefield is worth a thousand years of peace.' Italy declared war on the Allies on June 10th, when France was on the verge of surrendering. It is theorized that Mussolini only joined the war when he saw that Germany would win. When Hitler heard the news, he remarked: 'First they were too cowardly to take part. Now they are in a hurry so that they can share in the spoils.'

Italy attacked Greece on October 28 from their military base in Albania. Mussolini's fantasies of an empire came crumbling down when his army was forced to retreat. With inadequate weapons and the absence of winter attire, the Italians struggled to take Greece. The British came to aid Greece and were able to force the Italians to withdraw, taking the battle into Albania. However, the Greeks now confronted the Germans who were trying to invade Greece as well.

The Germans invaded Greece on April 6, 1941 and Greece surrendered on April 23rd. Their Prime Minister shot himself while the swastika flew over the Acropolis. The English force in Greece pulled back to Crete, which was then attacked by the Nazis. The English were yet again forced to retreat. The Greeks endured horrendously under the Germans and many starved to death. Only 2% of Greece's Jewish population survived the war.